> and the immense display of merchandise, fruits, game, armour, and cutlery defies description. These articles are arranged in prodigious piles from floor to ceiling; in front of each sits the artificer or from amidst the heaped up profusion peeps out the trader at his visitors. The streets are so narrow, that a string of laden camels takes hours to press through the dense, moving, ever-varying crowds who all day long fill the thoroughfares . . . In and out of the crowds the women in their shroud-like veils, thread their passage, or seek an easier plan of forcing it, astride on horseback . . . The multitude is suddenly pushed aside by a long train of foot soldiery, the advance guard of some great chief, who rides proudly on, followed by a troop of cavaliers, glittering in embroidered cloaks and trappings, and brandishing their spears and matchlocks . . . After these waddle the elephants of the Shah, tearing down the outstanding water pipes from the flat roofs, or backing onto an ice or fruit shop.[17]

Through the noise and the press would come the cry of the water seller with his brass cup and leather bag, ‘Ab! Ab!’, the cry of the lines of blind beggars asking for alms and, at the end of the summer, the rhubarb sellers with their call of ‘Shabash rawash!’ [‘Excellent rhubarb!’].

After all the hardships they had been through, the British troops were enchanted and even a little dazzled: ‘They marvelled at the wonderful Chatta covered bazaar,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata, referring to the great arcaded market built by Shah Jahan’s Governor, Ali Mardan Khan, in the 1640s, around the same time as the Taj was coming up in Agra.

> They admired the fine cut-masonry pools and cisterns, the gardens equal to those of paradise, the fine buildings of a capital city, and the well-stocked shops . . . The English troops, numerous as the waves of the sea, had experienced much hardship on the route into Khurasan, and now rested in Kabul, eating meat and rice, almond marzipan, faluda [vermicelli pudding], grilled meats and kababs, with various fruits, grapes of the sahebi and khalili varieties, and the finest of all, khaya-e ghulaman, young men’s testicles. They nibbled raisins and grew plump after being semi-starved on vile Indian chillies, dal and chapatis. The proverb ‘the women of Kabul all have lovers, just as the wheat flour of Peshawar is all cut with maize flour’ was also quickly proved, as the soldiers rode the steed of their lust unbridled day and night.[18]

This latter entertainment was something the jaunty regimental chaplain, the Rev. G. R. Gleig, chose to draw a veil over when he described in his memoirs the various wholesome masculine activities which kept the British troops occupied in Kabul. ‘Wherever Englishmen go,’ he wrote,

> they sooner or later introduce among the people whom they visit a taste for manly sports. Horse racing and cricket were both got up in the vicinity of Kabul; and both the chiefs and the people soon learned to take a lively interest. Shah Shuja himself gave a valuable sword to be run for, which Major Daly, of the 4th Light Dragoons had the good fortune to win: and so infectious became the habit that several of the native gentry entered horses. The game of cricket was not, however, so congenial to the taste of the Afghans. Being great gamblers in their own way, they